IMPARTIAL ANALYSIS OF MEASURE J

Measure J is a special tax ordinance placed on the ballot by the Board of Directors of the Petrolia Fire Protection District. As a "special tax," Measure J must be approved by two-thirds of the voters voting in the election, and the funds raised may only be used for the specified purposes in the ordinance, which are "providing ongoing fire protection and emergency response services, including but not limited to fire suppression and prevention; emergency medical and rescue services; hazardous materials response; and the operation, maintenance, and acquisition of firefighting equipment, apparatus, facilities and necessary capital improvements to ensure the safety of the public and firefighting personnel."

Measure J would create a "parcel tax." This means each taxable parcel is charged a flat rate, depending upon its intensity of use. Parcels with one or more structures which may require fire suppression services, such as a home or business, would be taxed $95 per year. Parcels that have the potential to be developed, but are not, would be taxed $75 per year. Contiguous parcels under identical common ownership, regardless of whether they contain structures, would be taxed $160 dollars per year. This requires an approved application from the property owner. Some properties are exempt from the tax. This includes property owned by government entities, properties exempt from real property taxes under other laws, and parcels which do not have the potential for development.

These taxes may be adjusted for inflation each year based on the percentage change in the Consumer Price Index. The taxes would be placed on the secured tax roll and collected by the Humboldt County Tax Collector in the same manner as other property taxes.

Measure J includes a hardship waiver, which allows a tax exemption for property owners who fall within the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development's definitions of "very low" or "extremely low" income. Measure J also allows active volunteer firefighters in good standing with the district to apply for and receive an exemption from the tax. There is an appeal process by which a property owner can challenge the district's determination of the nature and use of a parcel or the calculation of the tax.

As required by state law, Measure J requires the creation of a special fund into which all proceeds will be deposited, and requires an annual report showing "(a) the amount of special tax revenues collected and spent by the District in the previous fiscal year, (b) the status of any project or work authorized to be funded by the proceeds of this tax, and (c) the funds carried over from previous years and to be carried over in future years."

The above statement is an impartial analysis of Measure J. If you desire a copy of the ordinance or measure, please call the elections official's office at 707-445-7481 and a copy will be mailed at no cost to you.

You may also access the full text of the measure on the county website at the following website address (www.humboldtgov.org/elections).

Argument in Favor of Measure J

Since 1951, Petrolia's volunteer firefighters have answered the call when their neighbors needed help. That commitment has not changed, but the cost and complexity of providing emergency services have.

Basic operational costs—including insurance, fuel, equipment, apparatus replacement, training, and regulatory requirements—continue to climb. We cannot expect volunteer firefighters to carry an ever-growing administrative and financial burden with resources that no longer keep pace with reality.

Measure J provides stable local funding through a flat special tax of $95 annually for improved parcels and $75 for unimproved parcels. To ensure fairness, the measure includes exemptions for qualifying low-income property owners and active volunteer firefighters, as well as a $160 flat rate for qualifying contiguous properties held under identical ownership.

Crucially, Measure J is part of a larger regional solution. Approval provides the local funding needed to continue the proposed reorganization of Petrolia, Honeydew, and Telegraph Ridge fire services into the Mattole Fire Protection District. Additionally, Measure J and reorganization together create the opportunity to secure a Property Tax Exchange Agreement with Humboldt County, bringing additional property tax dollars that residents already pay back to the area to support local fire and emergency services.

Together, these resources will create a more sustainable local fire service, with shared administrative support, reliable engines and equipment, stronger emergency response, and each community retaining its local fire department.

Dependable emergency service requires dependable funding. Measure J supports local control, supports our volunteers, and sustains local fire and emergency services for generations to come.

Please vote YES on Measure J.

/s/ Sara Hanover, Petrolia Fire Protection District Commissioner
/s/ Jeff Skehen, Petrolia Fire Protection District Commissioner
/s/ Chris Gilda, Petrolia Fire Protection District Fire Chief
/s/ Tanner Speas Telegraph Ridge Fire Protection District Fire Chief
/s/ Lars Samuels, Honeydew Volunteer Fire Company Fire Chief